

BEGC-101

Indian Classical Literature

Assignment July, 2025 & January 2026 Sessions

(Based on Blocks 1 - 4)

Max. Marks: 100

Answer all questions.

Section A

Answer with reference to the context in about 100 words each: $4 \times 5 = 20$

(i) *"That first creator of the Creator That Bearer of salutations offered with Holy Rites;
That one who utters the Holy Chants; Those two that order Time. That which extends."*

Answer: The lines refer to Brahma, the creator of the universe, who is addressed with reverence. He is associated with sacred rites and holy chants and is also connected with the ordering of cosmic time. The passage presents the creator as a divine figure responsible for maintaining the order of the cosmos. Its elevated language reflects the religious and philosophical atmosphere of Indian classical literature, where creation, sacred ritual and the regulation of time are closely connected.

(ii) *"Now I see no other course open but the fourth—punishment. The kings are
marching to Kurnkshetra to their doom!"*

Answer: The speaker realises that peaceful and corrective alternatives have failed and that punishment has become the remaining course. The reference to the kings marching towards Kurukshetra evokes the approaching catastrophe of the Mahabharata war. The statement conveys a sense of inevitability and foreboding. The battlefield is not merely a place of military conflict; it becomes the destination towards which the rival rulers move because of political ambition, conflict and the failure of reconciliation.

(iii) *"This music hall is empty! Where could the actors have gone? (reflecting) Ah! I got
it—The home of a sonless person is empty; he who doesn't have a real friend finds
all the time empty; the quarters are empty to a fool; and everything is empty to a
poor man."*

Answer: The speaker sees an empty music hall and uses its emptiness to reflect on human life. The passage develops a series of comparisons: a sonless person's home, the life of someone without a true friend, and the world of a fool or a poor person are described as empty. The statement therefore moves from a physical observation to a broader reflection on loneliness, companionship and social circumstances. Emptiness becomes both a literal condition and a metaphor for human deprivation.

(iv) *"One saw the fine work of making
cloths from silk, fur and cotton,
In the weavers quarters. Silk, cozy,
Sandalwood, agar, flawless pearls,
Gems, gold, and an endless profusion
Of fine ornaments were piled high
In the commodious streets."*

Answer: The lines describe a prosperous and well-organised urban marketplace. The narrator notices skilled weaving and the production of fine cloth from silk, fur and cotton. The streets are also filled with valuable commodities such as sandalwood, agar, pearls, gems, gold and ornaments. The description creates an image of economic activity, craftsmanship and material abundance. At the same time, the detailed catalogue of goods suggests the cultural richness and commercial importance of the city represented in the classical Tamil literary tradition.

Section B

Answer the following in about 350 words each: $4 \times 20 = 80$

1. Examine the theme of concealment in *Abhijnana Shakuntalam*, *The Loom of Time*.

Answer: Concealment is an important dramatic and thematic device in Kalidasa's *Abhijnana Shakuntalam* and in *The Loom of Time*. In *Shakuntalam*, concealment operates at several levels. Dushyanta initially conceals his identity while entering the hermitage, and his relationship with Shakuntala develops in a setting separated from the political world of the court. Later, the curse of Durvasa causes Dushyanta to forget Shakuntala, so the truth of their relationship becomes effectively concealed from his conscious memory. The lost ring, which functions as a token of recognition, extends this concealment. Until it is recovered, the connection between the king and Shakuntala remains hidden.

The concealment is therefore not simply deliberate deception. It is also produced by circumstances, memory, social distance and supernatural intervention. Shakuntala's pregnancy and her relationship with the king cannot immediately be recognised within the court. The resulting separation creates emotional tension and allows the play to move from union to loss and finally towards recognition and reunion.

The idea of concealment is also relevant to *The Loom of Time*, where time, memory and human relationships can hide or delay the understanding of truth. Characters may conceal feelings, intentions or experiences, while the passage of time changes the way events are understood. What is hidden in one moment may become clear later. Time therefore acts almost like a woven fabric in which separate events and emotions are gradually connected.

In both works, concealment creates suspense but also serves a deeper purpose. It tests relationships and reveals the limitations of human knowledge. Recognition becomes meaningful precisely because something has first been hidden. The movement from concealment to revelation therefore becomes a movement from confusion towards understanding. The theme demonstrates how memory, time, circumstance and social structures can separate people from truth, while eventual recognition restores emotional and moral order.

2. Why does Duryodhana plot and plan to vanquish the Pandavas? Comment.

Answer: Duryodhana's hostility towards the Pandavas is rooted in rivalry, insecurity, ambition and his desire to preserve political power. From an early stage, he regards the Pandavas as competitors for the Kuru throne. Their popularity, abilities and growing political influence intensify his fear that they may eventually displace him and his brothers. Instead of treating them as members of the same royal family, Duryodhana increasingly sees their success as a threat to his own position.

His jealousy becomes particularly strong because Yudhishtira is respected for his character and is considered a legitimate claimant to the throne. Bhima possesses exceptional physical strength, while Arjuna is an outstanding warrior. The Pandavas also gain powerful alliances through marriage and political relationships. Duryodhana therefore believes that their continued existence as an independent political group will prevent him from enjoying unquestioned authority.

Duryodhana's actions are also influenced by Shakuni and other supporters. The attempt to destroy the Pandavas through the lac house, the manipulation of the dice game and the humiliation of Draupadi show a pattern of political calculation combined with personal resentment. The dice game is especially important because it allows Duryodhana to attack the Pandavas through a formally accepted contest while relying on Shakuni's skill in gambling.

Yet Duryodhana's hostility cannot be explained only by external advisers. His own pride and refusal to compromise repeatedly deepen the conflict. Even after the Pandavas return from exile, he remains unwilling to make a peaceful settlement. His determination to retain power ultimately contributes to the war at Kurukshetra.

Thus, Duryodhana's plotting is driven by a combination of political ambition, jealousy, fear of rivals, family rivalry and wounded pride. His inability to accept coexistence with the Pandavas transforms a dynastic dispute into a much larger conflict. The episode also illustrates how personal ambition can turn political competition into destructive warfare.

3. How are the views of the state integrated with the theme of *Mrichchhakatika*?

Answer: Sudraka's *Mrichchhakatika* presents a lively picture of urban society in which ideas about the state are closely connected with everyday social life. Unlike a drama limited to royal characters, the play includes merchants, courtesans, gamblers, thieves, servants, Buddhist figures and ordinary citizens. Through these characters, it shows how political authority affects people outside the palace.

The relationship between state power and social justice becomes particularly visible through the conflict involving Charudatta and the oppressive ruler's officials. Charudatta is respected for generosity and moral character even though he has become poor. His treatment contrasts with the behaviour of characters who misuse authority for personal advantage. The play therefore creates a distinction between legitimate governance and arbitrary exercise of power.

The political dimension becomes more explicit through the revolutionary change of rulers. The oppressive king Palaka is challenged, and Aryaka emerges as a figure associated with a different political order. The change in government is not presented as an isolated palace event; it has consequences for the wider community. The plot suggests that rulers who ignore justice and public welfare create the conditions for resistance.

The play also connects political authority with law, wealth and social status. Characters move through courts, streets, markets and private houses, allowing the audience to see how different institutions function. The diversity of characters gives the drama a broad social range and makes the state part of the everyday world rather than a distant abstraction.

Thus, the theme of the state in *Mrichchhakatika* is integrated with its larger concerns of justice, love, social relationships and moral conduct. The play does not merely describe a political system; it examines how the quality of government can shape the lives of individuals and the stability of society. The movement from oppressive authority towards a more just political order reinforces the play's concern with ethical governance.

4. Write a detailed note on *akam* and *puram* themes and their corresponding landscapes in *Cilappatikaram*.

Answer: The classical Tamil literary tradition commonly distinguishes between *akam* and *puram*. *Akam* refers to the inner world of love, emotion and personal experience, while *puram* refers to the public world of war, kingship, heroism, generosity and social action. These categories are closely related to the idea of landscape, in which particular geographical environments are associated with particular emotional and social situations.

The major *akam* landscapes are the five *tinai*: *kurinji* (mountain), *mullai* (forest or pastoral region), *marutam* (agricultural river valley), *neytal* (seashore) and *palai* (arid or transformed landscape). Each landscape carries a characteristic emotional situation. *Kurinji* is associated with union, *mullai* with waiting, *marutam* with domestic or relationship conflict, *neytal* with anxious separation, and *palai* with painful separation and journeying.

Cilappatikaram uses this cultural framework while expanding it through a larger narrative that combines love, social life, travel, commerce, kingship and justice. The movement of Kannaki and Kovalan through different regions allows the poem to connect emotional experience with geographical space. Urban centres such as Puhar and Madurai are presented as socially and economically complex environments, while journeys through different landscapes create changes in mood and circumstance.

The *puram* dimension becomes especially visible in the descriptions of cities, rulers, public festivals, political power and the consequences of royal judgement. The tragedy of Kovalan's execution demonstrates how a king's decision can affect the entire social order. Kannaki's response transforms a private experience of loss into a public act of moral protest.

Therefore, *Cilappatikaram* brings the inner and outer worlds together. Its treatment of landscape is not merely geographical description; landscapes carry emotional, cultural and social meanings. The interaction of *akam* and *puram* enables the epic to move from personal love and separation to questions of justice, kingship and society, giving the work its broad literary and cultural scope.